

Hummingbird was arguably the quantum leap in terms of making Google's search results "smarter", because in addition to considering synonyms, it now also emphasised the context of each query. Michelle Hill, marketing manager at Vertical Leap, explains it as a need to "think about why people are looking for something" instead of simply looking at what they typed in as their query.

Pigeon's aim was to work in tandem with Google Maps and give more importance to search results geographically closer to the user. Naturally, this also impacted Google Maps search results. Searching for a grocery store near you is now more likely to throw up Old Uncle Jimmy's store on the corner of 14th street than it is to point you to the Big Bazaar at the end of the busiest lane in the center of the city.

OC master race

Panda itself was updated several times from February to April 2011, at which point it was made operational. It uses the number of links to a site and the number of queries about the site's brand to determine a ratio which in turn determines each individual page's factor. In May 2011, Google's webmaster blog published a guide to building high quality websites. It gave out a general idea of what Google thought about while trying to downgrade unhelpful websites. Trustworthiness – both for the information given and taken by the website – is paramount. Google also considers whether the article is written by someone with in-depth knowledge of the topic, and whether it is merely rehashed content with synonyms thrown in for fluff, eventually to nobody's benefit.

In 2012, the blog outlined what it termed "black hat" SEO techniques – aimed purely at getting a higher ranking and not actually helping users, these practices include keyword stuffing and paying for links and do not contribute to the user experience in any way. Nor do they make the website easier to index. Google doesn't like that one bit, so it decides to take a kitchen knife to such websites and ensures that their ranking decreases.

Reading between the lines

Google Hummingbird -- named so because of the need to be "precise and fast" -- represents a monumental change in the search engine's mechanisms. Riding on the back of its past updates Panda and Penguin, Hummingbird enabled Google to understand context behind queries, and therefore looked at the actual intent behind the searches rather than simply matching words.